

79 Jezebel

The foreign queen who brought Baal to Israel's throne and used power without conscience.

Jezebel was a princess of Sidon who married Ahab, king of Israel. She set out to make Baal the god of Israel. She fed hundreds of Baal's prophets at her own table and hunted down the prophets of the LORD. After Elijah's victory on Mount Carmel, one message from her sent him fleeing. When Ahab could not buy Naboth's vineyard, she arranged a mock trial and had Naboth stoned. Elijah foretold a shameful end for her, and years later Jehu fulfilled it at Jezreel. Her name became a byword, and the book of Revelation uses it for a false teacher who led God's people astray.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Izevel</i> . The meaning is debated
Family	Daughter of Ethbaal, king of the Zidonians; wife of Ahab (1 Kings 16:31)
Children	Mother of King Joram (2 Kings 9:22), and probably of King Ahaziah (1 Kings 22:52)
When	Queen of Israel c. 874–853 BC; queen mother until her death c. 841 BC
Key places	Sidon (Zidon), Samaria, Jezreel
Key people	Ahab, Elijah, Naboth, Jehu, the prophets of Baal
New Testament	Her name is used for a false prophetess at Thyatira (Revelation 2:20)

"And Jezebel his wife said unto him, Dost thou now govern the kingdom of Israel? arise, and eat bread, and let thine heart be merry: I will give thee the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite."

1 Kings 21:7, KJV

The life of Jezebel

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Scripture does not say when she married Ahab or how old she was.

- By c. 874 BC

● **Marries Ahab**

A Phoenician princess, daughter of Ethbaal of Sidon, marries Ahab of Israel. Ahab begins to serve Baal and builds a temple and altar for him in Samaria. *1 Kings 16:31-32*
- c. 860s BC

● **Kills the LORD's prophets**

Jezebel cuts off the prophets of the LORD, and Obadiah hides a hundred of them in caves. Meanwhile, 450 prophets of Baal and 400 prophets of the groves eat at her table. *1 Kings 18:4, 13, 19*
- After Carmel

● **Threatens Elijah**

Ahab tells her about the fire from heaven and the death of Baal's prophets. She swears to kill Elijah by the same time the next day, and the prophet runs for his life. *1 Kings 19:1-3*
- Later

● **Plots against Naboth**

Finding Ahab sulking, she writes letters in his name, arranges false witnesses, and has Naboth stoned. Elijah declares that the dogs will eat Jezebel by the wall of Jezreel. *1 Kings 21:5-23*
- c. 853-841 BC

● **Queen mother**

After Ahab dies, his sons Ahaziah and Joram reign in turn. She remains a powerful presence, and Jehu later names her idolatry as the reason there can be no peace. *1 Kings 22:51-53; 2 Kings 9:22*
- c. 841 BC

● **Dies at Jezreel**

She paints her face, dresses her hair, and taunts Jehu from a window. Her own servants throw her down. When men go to bury her, only her skull, feet and palms remain. *2 Kings 9:30-37*

Key activities

Scripture never shows Jezebel in worship or in private. It shows her using power. Read her story alongside Ahab's, because each shaped the other.

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- 1 Brought Baal to court.** Through her marriage, Baal worship became the royal religion in Samaria. Kings says she "stirred up" Ahab to evil. *1 Kings 16:31–33; 21:25*
 - 2 Persecuted the prophets.** She cut off the prophets of the LORD, and some survived only because Obadiah hid them. *1 Kings 18:4, 13*
 - 3 Fed the prophets of Baal.** Eight hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and of the groves ate at her table. *1 Kings 18:19*
 - 4 Vowed to kill Elijah.** Her message began, "So let the gods do to me, and more also," and Elijah fled to the wilderness. *1 Kings 19:2–3*
 - 5 Mocked her husband.** "Dost thou now govern the kingdom of Israel?" she asked, and took matters into her own hands. *1 Kings 21:5–7*
 - 6 Used the law to murder.** She sealed letters with Ahab's seal, proclaimed a fast, and set two worthless men to accuse Naboth of blaspheming God and the king. *1 Kings 21:8–14*
 - 7 Faced death defiantly.** She greeted Jehu with a taunt: "Had Zimri peace, who slew his master?" *2 Kings 9:30–31*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jezebel.

Old Testament

1 Kings 16:31–33	Her marriage brings Baal worship into Israel
1 Kings 21:25	Ahab's wickedness, "whom Jezebel his wife stirred up"
2 Kings 9:7	Jehu to avenge the prophets' blood "at the hand of Jezebel"
1 Kings 21:23; 2 Kings 9:36–37	The dogs at Jezreel, foretold and fulfilled
2 Kings 9:22	Her "whoredoms" and "witchcrafts," likely idolatry
Echo: Proverbs 14:1	The foolish woman plucks down her house

New Testament

Revelation 2:20–23	"That woman Jezebel" at Thyatira, likely a symbolic name
Echo: Mark 6:17–28	Herodias seeks the death of John the Baptist

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What steps did Jezebel take to get Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21:8–14)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jezebel's name was chosen as a warning to the church in Revelation 2:20?
3. *Apply:* Jezebel used a fast and a court to do evil. Where can good-looking processes hide wrong motives, even in you?
4. *Apply:* Jezebel "stirred up" Ahab. Whom do you influence most, and which way are you stirring them?